

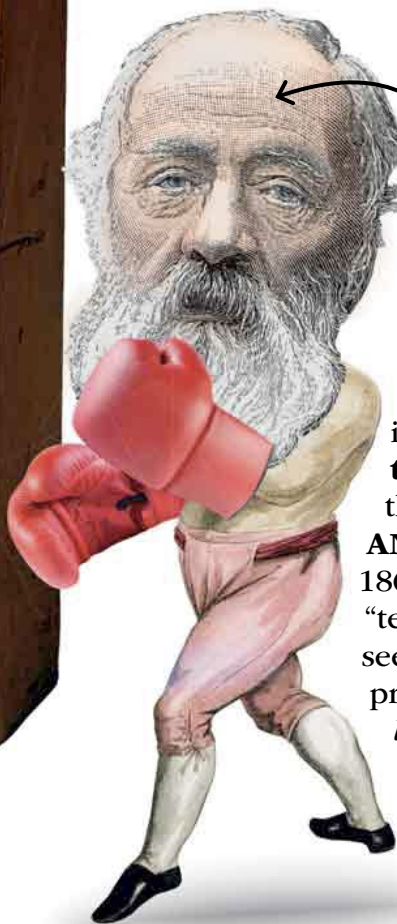
Patent fight

Bell began working on his idea and **PATENTED** it in 1876, since he knew other inventors were working on similar designs. His early phones featured a **lever to call the other phone** on the line, and a receiver that functioned as both an earpiece to hear the person on the other end and a mouthpiece to talk to them (though separate ear- and mouthpieces were soon developed). They were a **roaring success**.



By the way...

I patented a device much like a telephone five years before Bell did. But I was too poor to pay the \$10 fee to renew my patent, so I lost it.



Meucci constructed a telephonelike device at home to talk to his wife, who was ill at the time.

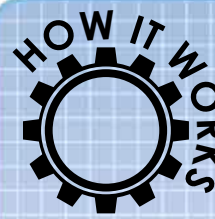
Mad Meucci

As Bell's telephone industry took off, a few of his rival inventors argued that he had **taken their ideas**. Among these was the Italian **ANTONIO MEUCCI**, who in 1860 had demonstrated his "teletrofono," which Bell had seen. Meucci was in the process of suing Bell, but his **legal claim ended** when he died in 1889.

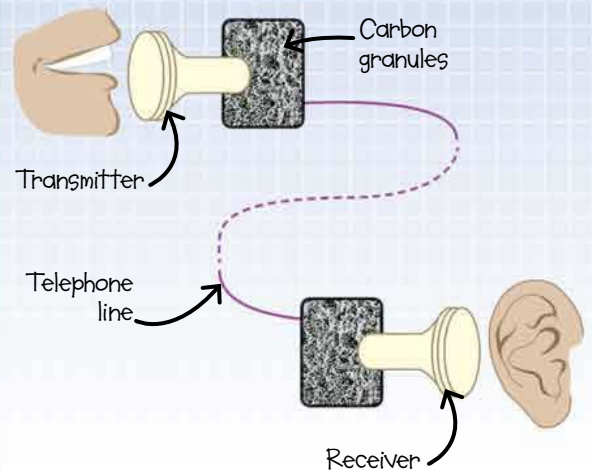
In 1963, the first electronic **PUSH-BUTTON TELEPHONES** were offered by **BELL TELEPHONE**, the company founded by Alexander Graham Bell.



Modern **SMARTPHONES** feature touch screens and cameras, and can connect to the **INTERNET**.



Early telephones used a thin metal disk that vibrated when someone spoke into the transmitter, making fluctuations in a layer of carbon granules. This varied the electric current, provided by a battery, which then traveled across the telephone line to the receiver. The electric current caused the carbon grains in the receiver to vibrate and copy the original sound.



How it changed the world
By turning sound into electrical signals and back again, the telephone enabled people to talk to one another over long distances for the first time. It has become the most widely used communication device on Earth.